105. In the past three centuries, Indian Muslims have faced several existential crises, but they survived each time with huge support from the enlightened sections of Hindus. The first event was the end of the Mughal empire in 1857. Since Bahadur Shah Zafar was the symbolic leader of the revolt, Muslims had to face the wrath and anger of the British. Hundreds of them were publicly executed in Delhi.

The year 1947 marked another turning point in the history of Indian Muslims. Unfortunately, the country was partitioned in the name of religion and the regressive two-nation theory. Muslim *ulema* were at the forefront of those opposing Partition. Most Muslims did not endorse the divisive idea of Partition as they were not even voters under the Government of India Act, 1935, which confined franchise to the educated and propertied class. The majority of Muslims decided to stay in India of their free will and refused to migrate to Pakistan. The massive communal violence during and after Partition led to the killing of half a million people. After an initial wave of riots, the Hindus of the country, under the leadership of Jawaharlal Nehru, stood up for the cause of the minorities. India opted for a liberal, secular democracy that assured Muslims that the State will not have a religion of its own and that they will have full religious and cultural freedom in the modern and progressive India. In subsequent decades, the Supreme Court has upheld both secularism as well as minority rights as part of its basic structure, which cannot be changed even by a constitutional amendment.

This author is not averse to India becoming a Hindu Rashtra as, under it, heavens won't fall for the Muslims. It cannot take away their citizenship or deny them the fundamental rights available to other citizens. It won't ask them to leave the country. In fact, Hindus should worry more about such a possibility and should ensure that India does not follow the disastrous path of Pakistan. Hinduism would be the worst affected as in every theocracy, it is the State that dominates and appropriates the official religion.

In 1992, Hindu fanatics demolished the Babri mosque and Muslims sank into depression. The secular and liberal Hindus once more not only condemned the demolition in the strongest possible words but also extended a helping hand to the demoralised community. In the Babri Mosque judgment (2019), the Supreme Court itself held the demolition to be an 'egregious wrong'. The Muslim community survived this onslaught. In 2002, the ugly face of communal violence returned in Gujarat. But more than a dozen police officers and several leaders have been convicted and punished. In 2019, the Supreme Court awarded Bilkis Bano, who was gangraped during the 2002 riots, compensation of Rs 50 lakh.

DEFEATING THE BJP—OR ANY PARTY—IS THE BURDEN OF THE HINDU MAJORITY, NOT THE MUSLIMS

In 2014, the Modi government took office. Soon after, we had cases of mob lynching on allegations of possession of beef. Muslims were the worst victims and some 35 people were brutally killed. Subsequently, the prime minister himself condemned the so-called *gau rakshaks* as criminals. 'Love jihad' too dominated the public discourse for some time, leading to even the Supreme Court ordering an NIA (National Investigation Agency) probe. The latter did not find any evidence of motivated and systematic 'love jihad'.

The recent public calls for genocide, hate speech, playing of *Hanuman Chalisa* during *azaan*s or desecration of mosques will not be able to either dampen the Muslim spirit or solve the so-called Muslim question.

Indeed, the recent developments are more worrisome for Hinduism as a few lumpen elements have hijacked it and are damaging its image as the world's most tolerant religion. The speed with which the local administration bulldozing houses of alleged miscreants without due process of law is lowering our image as a country with a rule of law. Majoritarianism should worry the Hindus. They need to come forward to say no more hate, abuse and vandalism in their name.

Religious processions leading to communal violence are part of an old script. Muslims must demonstrate utmost patience and not react to any provocation. They must support a total ban on the use of loudspeakers by all communities.

Indian Muslims must have the satisfaction that rather than being excluded by the extreme right, they are accorded a place of prominence in its political narrative. They are at the centre of all debates, discussions and electoral strategies. It is the failure of the Hindu extreme right. It means it needs Muslims. The easy route to power is not really the 'othering' of Muslims but rather their centrality. All election speeches are about them.

However, Muslims, too, must realise that, as a minority, they need not take the responsibility of defeating any political party, including the BJP. It is the burden of the majority to decide the fate of political parties. The RSS chief in his speeches has been rightly blaming the British for the present communalism and hostility between Hindus and Muslims. Since the RSS is committed to nation-building and has influence over the current political dispensation, it, and nobody else, must lead the battle against communalism and prevent state governments from continuing the British policy of divide and rule. ■